45 per cent say it is acceptable to withdraw after saying 'yes'; 48 per cent say it is not; only 28 per cent say a woman who withdraws consent mid-situation is seen as reasonable. Most say she is viewed as confusing, manipulative or dramatic.

The survey quantifies this distance through a Consent Empowerment Index built from 20 perception and experience inputs (*see box*). On a 0-100 scale, women's understanding of consent scores about 59, while their lived experience scores about 44. Awareness runs roughly 15 points ahead of autonomy. The overall index settles around 52.

The Performance of Refusal

The first test is the simplest: can a woman say 'no'? Around 56 per cent say they directly refuse when they do not want to do something. But 41 per cent either soften refusal with excuses or go along despite wanting to refuse. For a large share of Indian women, refusal is a performance to be staged, justified and managed.

A 'no' is rarely treated as complete in itself. It demands a socially acceptable reason, illness, family, timing, fear. When women stay silent, the leading explanation is not agreement. Some 43 per cent cite wanting to keep the peace, followed by the belief that nothing would change.

Assertiveness carries a reputational toll. Three-fourths of respondents say society negatively labels women who refuse advances or set boundaries as difficult, arrogant, 'too modern' or characterless. This stigma cuts across education and employment categories.

The contradictions sharpen inside intimate relationships. Only 36 per cent say consent in an intimate situation must be explicitly stated, the rest rely on nonverbal cues, habit or situational understanding. About half say they clearly refuse unwanted sexual activity. And only 36 per cent say that when they change their mind after initially consenting, the change is respected.

Marriage remains the most contested space. About 51 per cent say they can refuse sex in marriage or long-term relationships and have that refusal respected, the rest report questioning, pressure or emotional guilt. A clear majority—66 per cent—believe rape can take place within marriage, and around 75 per cent support its legal recognition in some form. Around 17 per cent report being physically forced into intercourse by a husband or partner, and 16 per cent report being forced into unwanted sexual acts.

The Office, the Street, the Phone

Hierarchy complicates consent further. Around 36 per cent of women report uncomfortable pressure or special attention from someone senior, a boss, teacher or mentor. Only 44 per cent say they can comfortably refuse work-related requests that make them unsafe, 36 per cent can refuse but fear job consequences, and 12 per cent cannot refuse at all. Economic dependency makes it fragile. Workplace systems offer little reassurance: just 32 per cent report meaningful training or policies on harassment, while 36 per cent call existing policies formalities.

Public spaces remain a daily battleground. Nearly 48 per cent report unwanted touching, groping or invasive closeness in buses, trains, markets and streets. Around 70 per cent say they change their behaviour, routes, dress or timings at least sometimes to avoid it. The phone is another frontline—28 per cent report repeated messages after saying 'no', 28 per cent have received unwanted explicit images, and 24 per cent report online stalking or harassment.

What Actually Empowers

The survey's most counterintuitive findings concern who is empowered. Education sharpens the vocabulary of consent—legal rights, coercion, marital rape—but does not guarantee protection. More educated women report more harassment, not less, partly because they

CONSENT EMPOWERMENT INDEX

AGE: *Women aged 25-34 understand consent the best, at 59.9, but those aged 18-24 are least able to see their choices respected in real life, at 37*

18-24	58.8	37	47.9
25-34	59.9	47.1	53.5
35-44	59.2	46.8	53
45-54	58.4	47.3	52.9
55	56.8	43.5	50.2

EDUCATION: *Women with higher education score highest both in understanding consent, at 62.5, and in having their choices respected, at 49.1. Women with lower education score lowest overall at 48.4*

Lower	55.7	41.2	48.4
Middle	59	42.1	50.6
Higher	62.5	49.1	55.8

EMPLOYMENT: *Women in higher employment score highest, with 62.4 in understanding consent; middle-employment women have the lowest overall score of 45.6*

Lower	58.6	38.1	48.4
Middle	51.3	39.9	45.6
Higher	62.4	51.9	57.2

RELIGION: *Christian women score highest overall at 51.5, while Muslim women are lowest at 49.7*

Muslim	57.9	41.4	49.7
Christian	58.7	44.4	51.5
Sikhs	58.2	44.5	51.4

NOTE: Respondents in each category are scored on 20 selected consent-related questions. Each response is converted into a binary score: 1 for a consent-empowered or consent-respecting answer, and 0 for a weak, unclear or vulnerable response. 'Don't know', 'can't say' and 'not applicable' are also scored zero, as ambiguity is treated as vulnerability. The 20 questions are split equally. Ten assess